



Balance in simplicity

don't leave out anything essential while streamlining your design. To take the case of functional copies, a button label that says "OK" is too simple and says too little, compared to a button label that says "Send This Message Now", which says too much. The optimum label in this case would be "Send Message". It's not just about minimising volume, but also about maximising clarity. We need to find the sweet spot where it wouldn't make sense to take away anything or add something.

This principle doesn't only apply to writing, but to functional design as well, say with control structures such as menus. Another thing to remember: If the user cannot find it, it doesn't exist. Complex features are sometimes the most useful, and the feature or its presentation doesn't always have to be simplified, only its experience. While it's acceptable to aim for cleanliness and elegance, the design shouldn't hamper discoverability. As always, when in doubt, user-test!

If you think some feature is too complex to be detected by a novice user, you can incorporate methodologies such as 'Active Discovery'. Remember "Clippy", the Office Assistant from the old versions of MS Office? Well, if its makers were able to make its presence known way back when, you can do better! The main point of Active Discovery is letting the user know about features as and when they need them, instead of waiting for users to find them themselves. You can call their attention to these features by displaying